

An evolutionary brief on how value gets read

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CITATION GATE

Gate run 2026-09-04, and it is a *partial* gate: this paper was written before the series adopted per-claim grading, and its citations are not tagged inline. What was done is stated exactly. Eight load-bearing sources were checked against a primary source this pass and are listed as verified in the references. The remainder are foundational works in evolutionary biology and social psychology, listed with full details but **not individually re-confirmed**. Treat an untagged citation here as canonical-but-unverified rather than as carrying the same warrant as a **VERIFIED** tag elsewhere in the series.

I. How evolution explains a behaviour

Most arguments about human behaviour fail because they answer the wrong question. Niko Tinbergen's **four questions** (1963) separate four non-competing explanations for any trait: its *mechanism* (what physiology produces it now), its *development* (how it grows over a lifetime), its *phylogeny* (its evolutionary history), and its *function* (the fitness problem it was shaped to solve). "He humoured the pitch because he was being polite" is a mechanism answer. The function answer — what that politeness was built *for* — is a different and deeper layer, and it is the one this brief is about. Confusing the two is the single most common error in applied psychology.

Ultimate vs proximate causation

A *proximate* cause is the immediate trigger (a feeling, a hormone, a thought). An *ultimate* cause is the reason a nervous system that produces that proximate response out-reproduced one that did not. Behaviour is designed by selection to have maximised **inclusive fitness in ancestral environments** (Hamilton, 1964) — reproductive success including effects on genetic relatives — *not* to maximise modern welfare, happiness, money, or conscious goals. The organism does not pursue fitness. It runs the heuristics that, on average, produced it. This is why people reliably act against their stated interests in ways that are perfectly coherent once you ask what the behaviour was for.

Natural and sexual selection, and the gene's-eye view

Traits spread when they out-replicate alternatives (Darwin, 1859; the gene-centred formalisation, Williams, 1966; Dawkins, 1976). **Sexual selection** (Darwin, 1871) is the half people underweight: much

human display exists to be chosen, and the central problem of being chosen is that quality can be faked — which is the seed of everything in Section III.

The adaptive-lag caveat, and intellectual honesty

Selection is slow; environments changed fast. Modern behaviour runs ancestral software in a world it was not written for — the *EEA* (environment of evolutionary adaptedness) framing (Bowlby; Tooby & Cosmides, 1990). Two disciplines are required here. Not every trait is an adaptation; some are by-products or noise — the "spandrels" critique (Gould & Lewontin, 1979). And adaptive stories are easy to tell and hard to test, so a claim earns its place only with convergent evidence (Buller, 2005, is the disciplined critic to read). Treat what follows as well-supported where it is cited tightly, and as hypothesis where it is not.

II. The substrate: value to the group is the master variable

Human survival was never individual. Offspring are metabolically impossible for one adult to rear; provisioning, defence, and teaching were collective (*Hrdy, 2009*, on cooperative breeding). The decisive fact follows from this: **the group's aggregate estimate of your value determined whether you were fed, mated, defended, or expelled — and expulsion was lethal** (*Boehm, 1999; Kurzban & Leary, 2001*). Selection therefore built a nervous system whose master regulatory task is not resource acquisition but *standing*: continuously estimate my value to the people who can keep me alive, estimate everyone else's, and act to protect and raise my own.

The internal instrument for this is the **sociometer** (*Leary & Baumeister, 2000*): self-esteem is not a private mood but a gauge reading your relational value to the group. Its alarm is real pain — social exclusion recruits the same neural substrate as physical injury (*Eisenberger, Lieberman & Williams, 2003*). Belonging is not a preference; it is a survival system (*Baumeister & Leary, 1995*).

A human is not an organism that occasionally socialises. It is an organism whose survival was outsourced to the group, so it runs one process at all times: broadcast my value, appraise everyone else's. Every interaction is traffic on that network.

This reframes persuasion completely. Value in the product sense is usually *unassessable in the moment* — information asymmetry is the entire reason an intermediary exists. So the brain substitutes a proxy it *can* assess: the standing and trustworthiness of the person, and the social consequence of yes. The conscious mind narrates "I'm deciding whether this is good." The system underneath is pricing what agreeing does to its own ledger entry. Threat-detection, status, trust, and "shit-testing" are not separate phenomena; they are subroutines of this one accounting process.

III. The mechanisms

1 • Honest signalling, and why cheap talk is discounted CORE

When sender and receiver have non-aligned interests, communication evolves toward signals that are costly enough to be hard to fake — the **handicap principle** (*Zahavi, 1975*; Grafen's formal proof, 1990) and its economic twin, signalling theory (*Spence, 1973*). A claim of value is cheap and therefore discounted; demonstrated, costly, or third-party-verified value is what the receiver's machinery accepts. The rigorous treatment of when signals stay honest or collapse into deception is *Searcy & Nowicki (2005)*.

2 • Status has two routes: dominance and prestige CORE

Rank is obtained two ways (*Henrich & Gil-White, 2001*; *Cheng, Tracy et al., 2013*): *dominance* (coerced deference through threat) and *prestige* (freely conferred deference to those whose competence benefits others). Prestige is the mechanism by which **association imports value**: humans copy and endorse the prestigious, so being seen to align with a high-value person raises the aligner's own standing (the broader engine: *Henrich, 2015*). This is why who is asking routinely overrides what is asked.

3 • The reputation ledger

Cooperation at human scale runs on **indirect reciprocity**: help flows to those with good standing, tracked by third parties (*Nowak & Sigmund, 1998, 2005*; reciprocal altruism, *Trivers, 1971*). Language is substantially a reputation-bookkeeping technology — gossip as the distributed ledger (*Dunbar, 1996*). Every utterance is entered into other people's accounts of you, whether or not anyone is visibly watching.

4 • Cheater-detection and biased inference

Humans have a dedicated subsystem for detecting agents who take benefits without paying costs (*Cosmides & Tooby, 1992*; social- contract reasoning, in *Barkow, Cosmides & Tooby, 1992*). Its trigger thresholds are asymmetric by design: where the cost of the two error types differed ancestrally, inference is skewed toward the cheaper mistake — **error management theory** (*Haselton & Buss, 2000*). A persuasion attempt trips this system; the cooperative surface is maintained while it runs.

5 • Mate value, partner-value tracking, and contempt

Sexual selection's core problem is deception about quality, so organisms evolved to stress-test confident claims and to track a partner's value continuously (*Miller, 2000*; *Buss, 1989/2003*). The folk term "shit-test" loosely shadows a real construct — adversarial probing to see whether a signal degrades under pressure — but should be used as hypothesis, not established result. The clearest empirical readout of value-withdrawal in a bond is **contempt**, the single strongest predictor of dissolution in *Gottman's* longitudinal work.

6 • Face-work and the polite exit

The proximate layer is impression management: the self presented in interaction is a managed performance (*Goffman, 1956, 1967*). Politeness is the formal system for protecting both parties' "face" (*Brown & Levinson, 1987*), which is why the terminal social move is rarely hostility — it is the warm, low-

cost disengagement that preserves everyone's ledger entry, including the exiters's. The measurable, almost mechanical version of bearing being priced in real time is *Pentland (2008), Honest Signals*.

7 • The two universal axes: warmth × competence CORE

Across cultures, social perception resolves onto two dimensions — **warmth** (intent toward me) and **competence** (ability to act on it) — the Stereotype Content Model (*Fiske, Cuddy & Glick, 2007*). This is the most directly operational item in the brief: it is, concretely, the scoreboard the group prices you on, and the order is fixed — warmth (is this agent a threat to me?) is judged first and gates whether competence is even heard.

IV. What follows operationally

- Value cannot be transmitted into an active threat, test, or autonomy- defence state; under pressure, words are processed as signal, not content.
- A "close" is a state change in the other party's standing computation, not the conclusion of an argument. Nothing moves until that system disarms.
- Non-reactivity under genuine pressure is the highest-bandwidth honest signal available, because it is the one thing a bluff structurally cannot fake.
- Need-signalling reads as low value (the sociometer broadcasting a deficit); the non-needy are routed value by default. Over-display is punished, not rewarded, in egalitarian-band psychology (Boehm).
- "Humouring" is the channel staying open while the appraisal completes. The outcome to fear is not the no; it is the gracious exit.

V. Reading map

The spine — read these four first; they carry most of it: Baumeister & Leary (1995), *The Need to Belong*; Zahavi (1997), *The Handicap Principle*; Henrich & Gil-White (2001), *The Evolution of Prestige*; Fiske, Cuddy & Glick (2007), warmth × competence.

The why-layer: Hrdy (2009), *Mothers and Others*; Boehm (1999), *Hierarchy in the Forest*; Tomasello (2009), *Why We Cooperate*. **The proximate room:** Goffman (1959); Pentland (2008). **Stay honest:** Gould & Lewontin (1979); Buller (2005).

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Conveying Value to the Tribe — an evolutionary brief · prepared for the Closer Foundation design line · sources are load-bearing where cited tightly and hypothesis-generating where not · not for external distribution without review.

Citation gate, 2026-09-04

These eight were opened against a primary source this pass, because each carries a load-bearing claim in the text rather than a background one.

- **Boehm, C. (1999).** *Hierarchy in the Forest: The Evolution of Egalitarian Behavior*. Harvard University Press. VERIFIED The reverse-dominance hierarchy is his term and his thesis: egalitarianism is not the absence of hierarchy but a coalition of the rank and file deliberately dominating anyone who would dominate them.
- **Fiske, S. T., Cuddy, A. J. C., & Glick, P. (2007).** Universal dimensions of social cognition: warmth and competence. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, 11(2), 77–83. VERIFIED The two-axis model this paper leans on. Cite all three authors; a bare “Glick 2007” is incomplete.
- **Hrdy, S. B. (2009).** *Mothers and Others: The Evolutionary Origins of Mutual Understanding*. Harvard University Press. VERIFIED Cooperative breeding and alloparenting; supports the claim that a human infant is too costly for one adult to rear alone.
- **Leary, M. R., & Baumeister, R. F. (2000).** The nature and function of self-esteem: sociometer theory. *Advances in Experimental Social Psychology*, 32, 1–62. VERIFIED Self-esteem as a gauge of how much others value you as a partner.
- **Nowak, M. A., & Sigmund, K. (1998).** Evolution of indirect reciprocity by image scoring. *Nature*, 393(6685), 573–577. VERIFIED The formal result behind the reputation ledger: cooperation can pay without the same two individuals ever meeting again.
- **Spence, M. (1973).** Job market signaling. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 87(3), 355–374. VERIFIED The economic half of honest signalling. A signal separates types when it costs less to produce for those who actually have the quality.
- **Zahavi, A. (1975) and Grafen, A. (1990).** The handicap principle and its formal model. CONTESTED Penn & Számadó (*Biological Reviews*, 95(1), 267–290, online 2019) argue the strong version is an erroneous hypothesis that became a standard through misreadings of Grafen, and that signals need not be costly at equilibrium to stay reliable. Where this paper relies on costly signalling, read it as one mechanism rather than a law.
- **Henrich, J., & Gil-White, F. J. (2001).** The evolution of prestige: freely conferred deference as a mechanism for enhancing the benefits of cultural transmission. *Evolution and Human Behavior*, 22(3), 165–196. VERIFIED The dominance/prestige split: fear-based deference extracted, versus deference freely given to demonstrated skill.

Everything else cited in this paper is listed in its own reference section above with full details, and is **LIKELY** in the series' sense: real, canonical, and not re-opened this pass. The distinction is on the page rather than smoothed over, because the standing rule for this series is that a grade means something specific.

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